

4th of July 2026 in Washington, DC

Day Trip Itinerary from the Fort Meade Area

Built for a group of 4+, Saturday, July 4, 2026 — National Mall fireworks + daytime sightseeing

ACTION NEEDED: Register for Free Fireworks Tickets Now

The Salute to America celebration and fireworks on the National Mall require a free ticket reservation — you cannot just show up. Registration is first-come, first-served, and tickets are capped at 4 per mobile phone number, so your group of 4+ will need more than one phone number to register everyone.

Doors open at 1:00 PM. You'll get a confirmation text after signing up — you must verify by replying to that text or your reservation doesn't lock in.

Do this before you finalize the rest of the trip — if tickets run out for your preferred entry, it changes your whole plan.

→ [Register for tickets — events.freedom250.org](https://events.freedom250.org)

Before You Plan: 2026 Is Not a Normal July 4th

Washington is hosting Freedom 250 / “Salute to America,” the kickoff of the nation's 250th-anniversary celebrations. It's been designated a National Special Security Event — the same security tier as a Super Bowl or inauguration.

Fireworks start around 11:00 PM (not the usual 9:00 PM) and run up to 45 minutes — the largest show in National Mall history. Security magnetometers open at 1:00 PM, with a strict clear-bag policy, government-ID requirement, and no chairs/coolers/aerosols.

Both MARC and Amtrak stop running well before the fireworks end — trains are a fine way to get INTO the city, but not a way to get home that night. See the Transportation Reality Check below before you commit to a plan.

Heat alert: forecasts show highs near 100°F with a heat index of 105–110°F. Plan for serious sun/heat exposure if you're outside midday.

Transportation Reality Check

Run the numbers before you choose a method — the train schedules genuinely don't support a normal “fireworks, then go home” night this year.

Method	Works to get IN?	Works to get HOME after fireworks?	Why
MARC (Penn Line)	Yes — Saturday service runs from	No	Last Saturday train leaves Union Station at 10:55 PM, before the 11 PM fireworks even start.

Method	Works to get IN?	Works to get HOME after fireworks?	Why
	Odenton/BWI		
Amtrak (BWI → Union Station)	Yes — frequent, reliable	No	Last Amtrak departure from Union Station to BWI is around 10:00 PM.
Drive + Metrorail (recommended)	Yes	Yes	Metrorail runs until 2 AM on July 4 with free fares after 5 PM — the only mode built for the late finish.
Drive + park near the Mall (ParkWhiz, etc.)	Yes, but expect gridlock	Difficult	Street closures run June 24–July 11; downtown garages will be jammed for hours after the show.

Recommended Plan: Drive + Metrorail

Given the late fireworks and extreme heat, the simplest reliable plan is to drive about 20–25 minutes from the Fort Meade area to a Metro garage, then ride the Green Line in. Metro parking is free on weekends, and rides are free system-wide after 5 PM on July 4 — which covers your entire return trip.

Suggested park-and-ride: Greenbelt Metro Station (Green Line)

- **Drive:** ~20–25 minutes from Fort Meade via MD-32 / BW Parkway (I-295) / I-495.
- **Parking:** Free on Saturdays — normally \$8.95/day, weekend parking is free at all Metrorail garages.
- **Ride:** Greenbelt → L'Enfant Plaza or Smithsonian station, ~30–35 minutes, one transfer or direct depending on train.
- **Fare:** Pay-per-ride before 5 PM (roughly \$2–\$6 depending on distance/time); completely free 5 PM–2 AM on July 4.
- **Tickets:** Get a SmarTrip card or add it to Apple Pay/Google Pay before you go — buy/load at wmata.com or any station kiosk.

Alternative park-and-ride stations if Greenbelt fills up: New Carrollton (also a MARC stop, Orange Line) or College Park (Green Line) — same free weekend parking, similar drive time.

Train Options (Good for the Trip In, or a Lower-Key Day)

MARC Train (Penn Line)

- **Nearest stations:** Odenton MARC Station is the closest stop to Fort Meade (about 10 minutes away); BWI Rail Station is a second option, about 15 minutes away.

- **July 4 service:** MARC runs a normal Saturday Penn Line schedule on July 4, 2026. Confirm closer to the date — MTA typically posts final holiday-weekend schedules about 4 weeks out.
- **Useful trip:** Odenton departs ~9:50 AM, arrives Union Station ~10:30 AM (next options: 7:55 AM and 11:20 AM). Last inbound train of the day departs Odenton 9:45 PM / arrives Union Station 10:25 PM.
- **Return limit:** Last Saturday departure from Union Station is 10:55 PM (arrives Odenton 11:20 PM) — too early for the 11 PM fireworks.
- **Fare:** About \$7 one-way (Odenton/BWI ↔ Washington). Buy via the CharmPass app, at station ticket machines, or onboard with cash (+\$5 surcharge if a machine was available).
- [MARC fares — mta.maryland.gov/marc-fares](https://mta.maryland.gov/marc-fares)
- [MARC Penn Line schedule — mta.maryland.gov/schedule/marc-penn](https://mta.maryland.gov/schedule/marc-penn)
- [CharmPass app / ticket info — mta.maryland.gov/marc-train-and-commuter-bus-tickets](https://mta.maryland.gov/marc-train-and-commuter-bus-tickets)
- [Official July 4 service alert \(check ~4 weeks before\) — mta.maryland.gov/4th-july-service](https://mta.maryland.gov/4th-july-service)

Good use of MARC this year: ride it in for the day program, then have one driver in your group bring a car to a Metro-accessible lot for everyone's ride home — or budget for a rideshare back to Odenton (expect heavy surge pricing on July 4 night; see Costs below).

Amtrak (BWI Marshall → Washington Union Station)

- **Nearest station:** BWI Rail Station, about 15 minutes from Fort Meade (shared with the MARC BWI stop).
- **Schedule:** Trains run roughly every 30 minutes to an hour throughout the day; trip takes about 30–40 minutes.
- **Fare:** Roughly \$7–\$19 one-way if booked in advance; prices rise closer to the date and on the holiday.
- **Return limit:** Last departure from Union Station back to BWI is around 10:00 PM — same limitation as MARC.
- [Book at amtrak.com or the Amtrak app](https://amtrak.com)

Amtrak is more frequent and comfortable than MARC and a good option if you want to come in later in the day, but it shares MARC's problem: it won't get you home after an 11 PM fireworks show.

Carpool & Parking Options

ParkWhiz (pre-booked parking)

ParkWhiz lets you reserve and prepay for a garage or lot spot near the Mall, which guarantees you a space but not a fast exit — downtown garages near the security perimeter will be slow to clear for hours after the fireworks, and several streets stay closed through July 11.

- [Washington, DC parking on ParkWhiz — from about \\$11/day](https://parkwhiz.com)
- [National Mall parking search](https://parkwhiz.com)

If you'd rather drive all the way in, book a garage near a Metro stop a few blocks outside the security perimeter (e.g., near L'Enfant Plaza or Federal Center SW) rather than directly on the Mall, and plan on a very late, slow exit.

Carpool matching

- **Commuter Connections:** Free regional ridesharing/carpool matching service run by the Metropolitan Washington Council of Governments — useful if you want to split the trip with neighbors or coworkers from the Fort Meade area.
- [Park & Ride lots directory — commuterconnections.org](https://commuterconnections.org)
- **Tip:** If you carpool, a single vehicle parking free at a Metro garage (see Recommended Plan above) is simpler and cheaper than splitting a paid downtown spot.

Suggested Itinerary — Saturday, July 4, 2026

Time	Activity
8:30 AM	Leave Fort Meade area, drive to Greenbelt Metro (free weekend parking).
9:15 AM	Board Metro Green Line toward L'Enfant Plaza / Smithsonian.
10:00 AM	Arrive National Mall area. Great American State Fair grounds open at 10 AM (free, runs to midnight on July 4) — enter at 12th & Jefferson SW or 7th & Jefferson SW/Madison NW.
10:00 AM–12:30 PM	Morning program: American Veterans Center Salute to America Parade, plus state-fair pavilions and exhibits. Stay hydrated — heat builds fast.
12:30–1:00 PM	Early lunch before security lines build; security magnetometers for the main event open at 1:00 PM.
1:00–2:00 PM	Pass through security if heading into the main Salute to America venue (clear bag only, valid ID, no chairs/coolers/aerosols).
2:00–6:00 PM	Hottest part of the day — duck into free, air-conditioned Smithsonian museums (Air & Space, American History, Natural History) or stay in shaded/misting areas. Refill water often.
7:00 PM	Evening broadcast program begins: Joint Armed Forces Orchestra and speakers.
~11:00–11:45 PM	Fireworks — 850,000 shells from 10 launch sites including the Lincoln Memorial Reflecting Pool and Potomac River barges.
11:45 PM–12:30 AM	Exit with the crowd toward your Metro station. Expect 30–60 minutes to clear station entry points — this is normal and expected by WMATA.
12:30–1:30 AM	Free Metro ride back to Greenbelt, drive home (~20–25 min).

If the late finish and heat are too much for your group, an easier version of this day is to do the morning parade and State Fair, leave by mid-afternoon, and watch fireworks from a quieter spot instead (see Alternatives below).

Cost Estimate (Group of 4)

Item	Recommended Plan (Drive + Metro)	MARC Plan (in only)	Amtrak Plan (in only)
Parking	\$0 (free weekend Metro garage)	Odenton lot — limited, arrive early	BWI lot, ~\$9/day
Transit fare	~\$3–\$6/person one-way; free after 5 PM → ~\$12–\$24 total	~\$7/person one-way → ~\$28 round trip for 4	~\$7–\$19/person one-way → ~\$28–\$76 round trip for 4
Gas (round trip)	~\$5–\$8 total	~\$3–\$5 to station	~\$5–\$7 to station
Return after fireworks	Included (free Metro)	Rideshare likely needed: \$80–\$150+ for the group with July 4 surge pricing, plus heavy traffic	Same rideshare risk as MARC
Food & drinks (full day)	~\$30–\$50/person → \$120–\$200 total	Same	Same
Estimated total	~\$160–\$240	~\$230–\$330+ (with rideshare return)	~\$230–\$350+ (with rideshare return)

State Fair admission, the parade, and the Salute to America program are all free. The only real spending is food, drinks, transit fare, and possibly souvenirs or paid Ferris-wheel-style attractions at the State Fair.

Where to Buy / Reserve Everything

- [Fireworks/Salute to America tickets \(free, required\) — events.freedom250.org](https://events.freedom250.org) — Max 4 per phone number — register first
- [MARC tickets — CharmPass app or mta.maryland.gov](https://mta.maryland.gov)
- [Amtrak tickets — amtrak.com or the Amtrak app](https://amtrak.com)
- [Metro SmarTrip — wmata.com or Apple Pay/Google Pay](https://wmata.com)
- [ParkWhiz — reserve downtown DC parking in advance](#)
- [Commuter Connections — carpool matching & park-and-ride lots](#)
- [Official event info, road closures & security rules — 250.dc.gov](https://250.dc.gov)
- [Freedom 250 / Salute to America schedule](#)
- [Great American State Fair details](#)
- [NPS prohibited items list](#)

Extra Tips

Security & what to bring

- Only one small, clear/see-through bag per person (or a small clutch); diaper bags allowed with a young child.
- No chairs, coolers, or aerosols — that includes spray sunscreen and bug spray. Bring lotion sunscreen instead.
- Government-issued photo ID required for entry — “no exceptions” policy per the Mayor's office.
- To cross from one side of the Mall to the other without going through screening, use 3rd Street or 14th Street.
- 7th Street (Constitution to Independence) and 4th Street (Pennsylvania to Independence) are closed to vehicles June 24–July 11. On July 4 itself, the Theodore Roosevelt and Arlington Memorial bridges also close.

Beat the heat

- Forecast highs near 100°F with a heat index of 105–110°F — treat this like a serious-heat day.
- Bring an empty refillable water bottle (clear bags only) and refill at water stations or inside museums.
- Plan your 2–6 PM block around air-conditioned Smithsonian museums — they're free and a built-in heat break.
- Wide-brim hats, lightweight clothing, and lotion sunscreen reapplied often.

If the late night isn't for your group

Consider splitting the day: do the parade and State Fair in the morning, head home mid-afternoon via MARC or Amtrak before the worst heat and crowds, and watch fireworks from home or a local spot instead. If you still want fireworks without the National Mall crush, Washingtonian recommends:

- Meridian Hill Park or Cardozo Education Campus — elevated views, far less crowded.
- Georgetown Waterfront Park, or a paid fireworks cruise (City Cruises, Sea Suite Cruises).
- Gravelly Point or Lady Bird Johnson Park (Mount Vernon Trail, Virginia side) — classic plane-watching spot with a clear river view of the fireworks.
- Anacostia Park / Navy Yard — NPS is running a second, smaller fireworks show there at the same time.
- [Washingtonian's full guide to alternate viewing spots](#)

Stay current

This event's logistics (fireworks time, security rules, road closures, train schedules) have been changing as the date approaches. Re-check [250.dc.gov](https://www.250dc.gov), [mta.maryland.gov](https://www.mta.maryland.gov), and [wmata.com](https://www.wmata.com) within the final two weeks before you go.